

Thermal Fractional Ore Processing System

Terrestrial Application — v5

Executive Summary

The Thermal Fractional Ore Processing System (TFOPS) is a zero-waste, zero-emission ore processing architecture that replaces conventional single-target extraction with staged thermal separation, capturing every mineralogical fraction as a characterized, marketable product. The design incorporates five changes from the original concept: EM (Lorentz force) separation at Bay 3, sub-atmospheric (0.5 atm) Bay 3 operation, CaO flux at Bay 2 before iron reduction, hydrogen combustion heating at all bays, and optional solar + SOEC for Phase 2 on-site H₂ production. These changes eliminate all four original showstoppers while producing zero atmospheric emissions.

Design basis: 1,000 t/hr copper porphyry ore at 0.5% Cu.
Phase 1 CAPEX: ~\$1.0B. Revenue: \$278/t ore across 12+ product streams. EBITDA: ~\$229/t ore with glass, ~\$24/t without glass. Both profitable. Both zero emission. Zero tailings, zero acid drainage, water use 0.003 m³/t.

Stage 1 — Feed Preparation

Ore is crushed only to the coarse size required to feed the thermal train — not to mineral liberation size as required by conventional flotation. This eliminates the majority of conventional processing energy. LIBS (Laser-Induced Breakdown Spectroscopy) sensors characterize incoming feed material in real time, providing elemental composition data that initializes bay temperature calibration before material enters the system. The ore body is continuously mapped as it is processed.

Stage 2 — Thermal Cascade

The architecture follows a convergent-divergent diamond topology optimized for throughput, thermal stability, and capital efficiency: 3× Bay 1 → 1× Bay 2 → 1× Bay 3 → 2× Bay 4 → 1× Bay 5.

Multiple parallel Bay 1 units process ore independently at the lowest temperature threshold. Their residues converge into a single Bay 2, concentrating expensive high-temperature infrastructure while allowing cheap low-temperature stages to scale for throughput. Blending residues from several Bay 1 units stabilizes the thermal characterization of feed entering the silicate melt stages.

All bays are heated by hydrogen combustion. The only combustion product is water vapor — no carbon dioxide, no nitrogen oxides, no atmospheric contaminants. This produces the cleanest possible bay atmospheres, enabling higher product purity and more accurate LIBS readings. Material is never returned to ambient temperature between stages — sensible heat is paid once and only the delta temperature is added at each subsequent bay.

Bay Sequence (All Five Design Changes Incorporated)

- Bay 1 (~840°C): Calcite decomposition. $\text{CaCO}_3 \rightarrow \text{CaO} + \text{CO}_2$. CO_2 captured in sealed bay as pure process CO_2 (no combustion contamination) for sale or mineralization. CaO collected as flux for Bay 2. SO_2 captured for sulfuric acid. Arsenic captured in multi-stage scrubbing system.
- Bay 2 (~1,100°C, CaO -fluxed): CaO flux from Bay 1 (28 kg/t) plus external CaO (2 kg/t) added BEFORE iron reduction. CaO lowers the liquidus of feldspars — CaO -albite eutectic ~1,040°C, CaO -orthoclase eutectic ~1,020°C. Feldspars and silicates melt and drain at 1,100°C while quartz (T_m 1,713°C) and iron oxides (FeO T_m 1,377°C) remain solid. This removes 80% of reactive

SiO₂ before Bay 3, preventing fayalite formation. Cu (T_m 1,085°C) melts and is recovered by density separation in heated settling vessel (~80%). Drained melt is mineral wool / E-glass fiber feedstock.

- Bay 3 (~1,200°C, 0.5 atm, H₂ reducing): Hydrogen serves as both heating fuel and chemical reductant. $\text{FeO} + \text{H}_2 \rightarrow \text{Fe} + \text{H}_2\text{O}$. Reaction product is water, not CO₂ — eliminates all carbon from reduction. Same chemistry as HYBRIT green steel process. EM (Lorentz force) separation deflects conductive metals (Cu, Fe) from non-conductive silicate slag — 5+ orders of magnitude conductivity contrast, no moving parts, TRL 7–8, gravity-independent. Sub-atmospheric pressure ensures any leak draws air inward. Cu recovery 98–99% combined (Bay 2 settling + Bay 3 EM).
- Bay 4 (~1,500°C): Iron-free silicates melt. Premium iron-free glass feedstock at \$600+/t — architectural, optical, specialty applications.
- Bay 5 (~1,650°C): Quartz melts with CaO (45 kg/t) + Na₂CO₃ (27 kg/t) flux. Soda-lime glass composition: ~83% SiO₂, 12.5% CaO, 4.5% Na₂O. Viscosity 10–50 Pa·s (vs 10⁶–10⁷ without flux). Refractory residue (chromite, zirconia, alumina) collected separately.

Energy System

Recommended: H₂ Combustion + Purchased H₂ (Phase 1)

Hydrogen combustion was selected over natural gas and oxy-fuel natural gas after systematic evaluation of all three options.

- Natural gas + air: \$755M CAPEX, \$28/t OPEX. Contaminates bay atmospheres with N₂. Releases ~987,000 t CO₂/yr. Contaminated CO₂ has no commercial value.

- Natural gas + oxy-fuel: \$1.1B CAPEX, \$24/t OPEX. Clean bay atmospheres. But creates ~1M t CO₂/yr requiring permanent disposal — geological storage with perpetual monitoring.
- H₂ combustion: \$950M CAPEX, \$47–52/t OPEX (at \$1.50/kg H₂). Zero combustion CO₂. Purest bay atmospheres (H₂O only). Only option with zero disposal/monitoring obligations.

All three are profitable without glass revenue. H₂ has the highest OPEX but eliminates all disposal and monitoring obligations permanently.

Optional: Solar + SOEC (Phase 2)

On-site solar (~3,100 MW, 24–31 km²) powers SOEC electrolyzers (~700 MW) to produce H₂ on-site, eliminating purchased H₂. Bays keep burning H₂ exactly as Phase 1. No SOFC needed — H₂ is burned directly for heat, not converted back to electricity. ~200 t H₂ storage provides 12-hour overnight buffer. Estimated CAPEX: \$1.5–2.5B. Facility electrical loads (~130 MW for mining, LIBS, town) supplied by grid, batteries, or small backup generator.

CO₂ Management and Mineralization

TFOPS produces ~614,000 t/yr process CO₂ from calcite decomposition at Bay 1. Because H₂ combustion generates no combustion CO₂, this is the only CO₂ in the system — captured as a pure stream inside a sealed bay.

- ~115,000 t/yr sold (food-grade, greenhouse, industrial) = ~\$16M/yr revenue
- ~400,000–500,000 t/yr mineralized into construction products: $\text{CaO} + \text{CO}_2 \rightarrow \text{CaCO}_3$. Calcium carbonate is the binder — replaces Portland cement entirely. CarbiCrete-style process, demonstrated at commercial scale.
- CO₂-cured blocks: +10–30% compressive strength, improved durability

- Carbon-negative certified building material. Permanent mineral sequestration. LEED/BREEAM points.
Government low-carbon procurement eligibility.

Result: zero CO₂ to atmosphere, zero geological storage, zero perpetual monitoring. The CO₂ is either sold or locked into premium construction products.

EM (Lorentz Force) Separation

The Bay 3 EM separator replaces the original centrifuge design. An electromagnetic field applies Lorentz force ($F = J \times B$) to conductive liquid metals while non-conductive silicate slag is unaffected. Five-plus orders of magnitude conductivity contrast provides highly selective separation.

- TRL 7–8 (established in aluminum and steel industries)
- No moving parts — eliminates all mechanical failure modes
- Gravity-independent — operates identically in zero-g, lunar, or terrestrial gravity
- Combined Cu recovery: 98–99% (Bay 2 heated settling + Bay 3 EM)

Sub-Atmospheric Bay 3 Operation

Bay 3 operates at 0.5 atm. The pressure differential ensures any leak draws ambient air inward rather than allowing reducing gas outward. H₂ escape is physically impossible under any single-failure scenario (H₂ explosive range 4–75% in air — same containment logic applies). All off-gas is actively pulled to the central gas management system.

Showstopper Resolution

- #1 — Bay 3 centrifuge at 1,200°C (TRL 3–4):
ELIMINATED by EM separation (TRL 7–8).
- #2 — Bay 3 reducing atmosphere containment:
ELIMINATED by 0.5 atm operation (gas escape physically

impossible).

- #3 — Bay 5 quartz viscosity (10^6 – 10^7 Pa·s):
RESOLVED by CaO + Na₂CO₃ flux (10–50 Pa·s soda-lime glass).
- #4 — Fayalite iron trapping (40–70% Fe lost):
RESOLVED by CaO flux at Bay 2 removing 80% of reactive SiO₂ before iron enters Bay 3.

Product Applications

Zero-Cost Inventory

All glass and stone output has zero production cost — byproducts of profitable metal extraction. Every sale at any price is pure profit. Material stores indefinitely at zero carrying cost. The worst case (never sold) is still better than conventional tailings.

Cast Stone and Glass

TFOPS cast stone replaces both natural granite on function (zero porosity, zero fracture planes, custom color throughout, any geometry, fully characterized) and laminate on cost (\$5–15/sq ft at scale vs \$10–30 for laminate). The stone market hierarchy collapses — a material that outperforms granite costs less than particle board.

Reconfigurable Pin Mold

An array of individually actuated refractory pins with a flexible refractory membrane between pins and molten pour. Upload 3D model → pins position → pour → custom product at commodity cost. Every piece different at same cost as identical. Pin resolution: 10 mm (structural) to 1 mm (decorative). TRL 6–8 for pin array technology (automotive/aerospace). Turns TFOPS from materials producer into digital manufacturing platform.

Integrated Building System

From one ore stream: stone blocks (load-bearing), iron-free glass (translucent panels), mineral wool insulation (Bay 2 slag), cast iron (structural hardware), CaO cement (mortar). Interlocking geometry: concave/convex for storage, radiused miter/dovetail for structural. Mortarless assembly, disassemblable, relocatable. All components carry LIBS provenance data.

Pre-Melted Glass Feedstock

Sold to existing glass manufacturers at 25% of their retail price — cheaper than their raw materials because it eliminates their melting cost. Pre-melted, pre-characterized, iron-free, homogeneous. Every glass manufacturer within shipping distance is a customer.

Applicability Across Mining

TFOPS applies to all solid rock mining where ore is processed by crushing and separation. 11 of 15 most-mined metals are in silicate host rock — directly compatible. Non-silicate hosts (carbonate, sulfide, phosphate) also work with different product mixes.

Only exceptions: brine extraction, solution mining, placer mining, coal, dimension stone quarrying. If you are mining to separate, TFOPS applies. If you are mining to keep the rock as-is, it does not. Exception: TFOPS products compete directly with quarry products (better consistency, carbon-negative certification).

The lower the metal grade, the more transformative TFOPS becomes. Gangue revenue (~\$200/t) is constant regardless of metal content. TFOPS makes low-grade deposits economic by monetizing the 99%+ of ore mass that conventional mining discards.

Process Control

LIBS sensors at every bay drain point provide real-time

elemental composition. H₂ combustion atmospheres improve LIBS accuracy — water vapor is the only combustion product, producing none of the spectral interference from N₂ or CO₂. Automated valves route material to primary product molds or catch basins based on LIBS readings.

Output Casting and Provenance Stamping

Every drain point feeds a product mold or catch basin mold. At the appropriate cooling point, a stamp presses identifying information into the surface: human-readable identifier plus machine-readable data matrix, linking to the complete LIBS data record for that pour. The information is physically part of the material.

Product Portfolio (12+ Revenue Streams)

- Copper metal: 4.0 kg/t ore at \$8,500/t = \$34.00/t ore
- Cast iron (Cu-bearing): 35 kg/t at \$350/t = \$12.25/t ore
- Bay 2 CaO-aluminosilicate glass: 401 kg/t at \$120/t (mineral wool feedstock)
- Bay 4 iron-free glass: 147 kg/t at \$600/t (optical, specialty)
- Bay 5 soda-lime glass: 336 kg/t at \$100/t (commercial glass)
- Sulfuric acid: 23 kg/t at \$80/t
- Engineered stone: 95 kg/t at \$40/t
- CO₂-cured construction blocks (carbon-negative certified)
- Refractory concentrate: 13 kg/t at \$200/t
- Volatile metals: 0.14 kg/t (mixed pricing)
- Calcium fluoride: 0.3 kg/t at \$300/t
- CO₂ sales: ~115,000 t/yr = ~\$16M/yr
- Engineered underground space at closure (data centers, cold storage)

Total revenue: \$278/t ore. Floor case (metals only): \$73/t ore, still profitable.

Environmental Profile

- Tailings: zero. No tailings pond, no liner, no monitoring wells, no perpetual care.
- Acid mine drainage: zero.
- Atmospheric CO₂: zero. All process CO₂ captured and mineralized.
- Combustion CO₂: zero. H₂ combustion produces only water vapor.
- Water: 0.003 m³/t (99.7% reduction vs conventional).
- Geological CO₂ storage: zero. No perpetual monitoring required.

Thermal Shock and Second Pass

Residue that did not melt at any stage is water-quenched. Thermal shock cracks grain boundaries along mineral interfaces. The water system is fully closed. Steam drives a small turbine before condensing and returning by gravity. Thermally shocked material is fed back for a second pass through only the relevant high-temperature bays.

Site Closure and Post-Mining

Residue blocks for void backfill are non-reactive, geometrically uniform, and fully characterized. Custom structural molds produce columns, arches, and wall panels. Excavated voids become usable subsurface space for data centers, cold storage, or research facilities. Mine closure becomes a revenue event.

Economics

Phase 1: H2 Combustion + Purchased H2

CAPEX: ~\$1.0B. Revenue: \$278/t ore. EBITDA: ~\$229/t with glass, ~\$24/t without glass. Annual cash flow: ~\$2.0B with glass, ~\$210M without. Both profitable. Both zero emission.

vs Conventional

Conventional at same ore body: \$2.5–3.5B CAPEX. Revenue: \$34/t (copper only). OPEX: \$85–120/t. At 0.5% Cu grade, conventional operates at or below breakeven — plus perpetual tailings liability.

Phased Deployment

Phase 1: H2 combustion + purchased H2 (~\$1.0B) — complete, profitable, zero-emission. Phase 2 (optional): Add ~3,100 MW solar + ~700 MW SOEC (\$1.5–2.5B) to produce H2 on-site. Phase 1 alone is sufficient.